

FACILITATOR ONLY / CONTAINS ASSET MAPPINGS

YOUTH FINANCETOPIA CHALLENGE

Newsroom & facilitator guide

Quarter-by-quarter market cards, source anchors, teaching notes and classroom safeguards.

2018-2022

VERSION 2.1
12 JULY 2026

CLASSROOM SIMULATION - NOT INVESTMENT ADVICE

Prices are simplified and rounded teaching traces. Headlines compress real themes into a fictional game timeline. Rumors are invented. Do not present the cards as dated historical reporting or as recommendations to buy or sell.

Students should receive fake names only. Keep this guide off the student-facing site until the debrief.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Keep the uncertainty. Teach the process.

The challenge works when students must decide what matters without being handed the real ticker, the future path or a perfect answer. The website releases only the current quarter's forward-looking cards and historical chart points earned so far. Those cards are evidence for predicting the next revealed quarterly mark, not explanations of the mark already on screen.

1 / BRIEF

Ask teams to open confirmed briefs first. Let them paraphrase the fact before discussing direction.

2 / QUESTION

Use the card's question to surface competing explanations. Reward a team that identifies what it still does not know.

3 / RUMOR

Reveal desk chatter only after the fact is understood. It may be useful, irrelevant or false; students must label it as unverified.

4 / DECIDE

Teams pin evidence, choose a view and confidence, write one sentence, then review quantity and estimated cash before the captain confirms.

Facilitator guardrails

- Never reveal the real mapping during live play.
- Do not tell teams which asset should rise or fall.
- Treat a well-reasoned hold as a valid decision.
- Separate outcome quality from decision quality in the debrief.
- Explain that all company and market references are historical classroom context, not current financial or medical guidance.

FACILITATOR KEY

Fake asset map

This page contains the answer key. The student website and student handouts must use fake names only.

GAME NAME	REAL-WORLD TRACE	TEACHING ROLE
Pulse Social	Meta Platforms / Facebook	Advertising, privacy, platform growth and rate sensitivity
Cedar Ridge Energy	Occidental Petroleum	Commodity exposure, acquisition leverage and balance-sheet repair
Aster Therapeutics	Eli Lilly	Defensive sales, research catalysts and manufacturing execution
Harbor Metal	Gold	Safe-haven demand, real yields, dollar strength and liquidity
Meridian Crude	Crude oil, mainly WTI	Demand, supply, storage, sanctions and trade routes
Atlas Currency Pair	EUR/USD	Relative policy, growth expectations and dollar cycles
Market Nerves Index	Cboe VIX	Broad-market expected volatility from SPX options

Accuracy notes that matter

FEAR GAUGE G

The VIX is based on S&P 500 index option prices and represents expected broad-market volatility. Meme-stock or single-stock call volume does not directly enter its calculation. A broad gauge can look calm while individual shares are chaotic. VIX products exist in real markets; the gauge is simply not tradable in this simulation.

FX PAIR F

The proxy follows EUR/USD quote direction: a higher value means euro strength and dollar weakness; a lower value means dollar strength. Students need this convention before interpreting a move.

MEDICAL HISTORY

The 2020 emergency-use card is a known-at-the-time historical scenario. FDA later revoked authorization for bamlanivimab when used alone. Do not treat the card as current medical guidance.

2018 NEWSROOM

Quarter cards: 2018

Release each card only when its game quarter is reached. Source IDs point to the appendix; the card wording is a fictionalized synthesis rather than a quotation.

**2018 Q1 / PULSE
SOCIAL**

Questions grow around customer data

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Lawmakers want clearer answers about how a large consumer network handles personal information. Advertisers have not changed their plans yet.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

A costly product redesign may be discussed behind closed doors.

ASK THE ROOM

Is this a short-term headline, or could it change the business model?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S01, S02

**2018 Q1 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS**

A steady business hints at another trial update

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Core medicine sales remain dependable while researchers prepare a new pipeline presentation.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Specialists think the pipeline may be broader than investors expect.

ASK THE ROOM

How much should a possible future result matter today?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S12

**2018 Q1 / PULSE
SOCIAL**

Usage and ad budgets stay resilient

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Privacy questions are growing, but user activity remains strong and large advertisers have not reduced their budgets.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Smaller advertisers may be increasing spending faster than expected.

ASK THE ROOM

Can strong operating momentum outweigh a serious long-term risk for one more quarter?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S01, S02

**2018 Q1 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX**

Tighter supply meets calmer markets

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Oil inventories are falling while producers remain disciplined. At the same time, broad demand for market protection is easing.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

A few major buyers may be locking in more fuel than usual.

ASK THE ROOM

Which assets benefit when physical supply tightens but financial fear falls?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S19, S28, S33, S34

**2018 Q2 / MERIDIAN
CRUDE****Supply looks tight - for now****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Export disruptions are supporting energy prices, but weekly inventory declines are becoming less consistent.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Some shipping desks say hidden stockpiles are building.

ASK THE ROOM

Which matters more: today's shortage or tomorrow's inventory?

DEBRIEF LENS

Trace the physical chain: demand, production response, storage and regional transport limits.

SOURCE IDS

S19, S33

**2018 Q2 / PULSE
SOCIAL, MARKET
NERVES INDEX****Growth warning shakes confidence****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

A large online platform warns that user growth and future profit margins may slow even though current advertising revenue is healthy.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Product teams may be spending heavily to address privacy concerns.

ASK THE ROOM

Does a strong current quarter matter if management lowers expectations?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S02

**2018 Q2 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS****Core medicines carry the quarter****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Established treatments are selling steadily while several research programs continue without a major setback.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Analysts may be raising long-term estimates before the next formal update.

ASK THE ROOM

How valuable is dependable growth when other sectors are becoming less certain?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S12

**2018 Q3 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY****Board studies a large expansion****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

An energy producer is exploring a deal that could increase output and also increase debt.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Management may announce something larger than the market expects.

ASK THE ROOM

When does growth become too expensive?

DEBRIEF LENS

Ask whether stronger commodity cash flow is enough to compensate for leverage and execution risk.

SOURCE IDS

S08

**2018 Q3 / PULSE
SOCIAL, MARKET
NERVES INDEX, ATLAS
CURRENCY PAIR****Rates and trade tension hit risky assets****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Borrowing costs are rising and trade tensions are weakening confidence. Investors are paying more for protection and cutting exposure to expensive growth companies.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Systematic funds may have more selling to complete.

ASK THE ROOM

Which assets are most sensitive when both rates and fear rise together?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Market Nerves Index, Atlas Currency Pair. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S20, S28, S32

**2018 Q3 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE****Supply catches up with demand****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Production is rising faster than consumption, and inventories are starting to rebuild after months of tight supply.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Exporters may compete for market share instead of cutting output quickly.

ASK THE ROOM

How does an unexpected surplus affect both a commodity and a debt-heavy producer?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S19, S33

**2018 Q4 / HARBOR
METAL****Safe-haven demand meets a strong currency****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Investors are nervous after a broad selloff, while higher yields and a firm US dollar remain headwinds for defensive metal.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

The latest bounce may be traders closing old bets rather than starting new ones.

ASK THE ROOM

Can an asset be defensive and still face macro pressure?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare safe-haven demand with the opportunity cost created by yields and dollar strength.

SOURCE IDS

S19, S23

**2018 Q4 / PULSE
SOCIAL, MARKET
NERVES INDEX****Policy makers sound more patient****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

After a sharp selloff, policy makers signal they can slow future rate increases if growth weakens further.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Large funds may be preparing to rebuild positions sold during the panic.

ASK THE ROOM

Can a change in policy expectations reverse fear before the economy improves?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S20, S28

**2018 Q4 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE**

Producers discuss supply restraint

CONFIRMED BRIEF

After a steep energy-price fall, major producers are considering output cuts while lower prices begin to support demand.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

The announced cuts may be larger than traders expect.

ASK THE ROOM

What usually happens after low prices trigger both less supply and more demand?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S19, S33

2019 NEWSROOM

Quarter cards: 2019

Release each card only when its game quarter is reached. Source IDs point to the appendix; the card wording is a fictionalized synthesis rather than a quotation.

**2019 Q1 / PULSE
SOCIAL**

Advertisers return, scrutiny remains

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Marketing demand is stabilizing after a difficult year, but policy questions have not disappeared.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Engagement may be improving fastest in smaller markets.

ASK THE ROOM

Does improving demand outweigh a risk that is still unresolved?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S03

**2019 Q1 / ATLAS
CURRENCY PAIR**

Central banks signal different paths

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Traders are comparing which central bank may ease policy first as global growth expectations soften.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Macro funds are preparing to sell every short-lived relief rally.

ASK THE ROOM

Which side of the pair has the stronger policy support?

DEBRIEF LENS

A higher proxy means euro strength and dollar weakness; compare policy and growth on both sides.

SOURCE IDS

S20, S21, S22, S32

**2019 Q1 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY**

Expansion plan raises financing questions

CONFIRMED BRIEF

An oil producer is pursuing a large acquisition that could increase reserves but leave the combined company with much more debt.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Some shareholders may oppose the deal unless terms improve.

ASK THE ROOM

When can buying more assets destroy value for existing owners?

DEBRIEF LENS

Ask whether stronger commodity cash flow is enough to compensate for leverage and execution risk.

SOURCE IDS

S08

**2019 Q1 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS,
HARBOR METAL,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX**

Defensive choices send mixed signals

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Medicine-pricing debate pressures healthcare shares while softer growth expectations increase demand for defensive metal and market protection.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Policy proposals may be harsher in headlines than in final law.

ASK THE ROOM

Why can two defensive assets move in different directions?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Aster Therapeutics, Harbor Metal, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S13, S23, S28

2019 Q2 / ASTER THERAPEUTICS
Pricing debate reaches healthcare
CONFIRMED BRIEF

Politicians are discussing medicine affordability while a major drugmaker invests in a smaller research business.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Researchers believe the acquired science may be worth more than the purchase price.

ASK THE ROOM

How do policy risk and innovation pull value in opposite directions?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S13

2019 Q2 / CEDAR RIDGE ENERGY, MERIDIAN CRUDE, MARKET NERVES INDEX
Trade dispute clouds industrial demand
CONFIRMED BRIEF

Factories and freight indicators are slowing as trade restrictions widen, weakening expected fuel demand and increasing uncertainty.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Producers may delay investment before they cut current output.

ASK THE ROOM

Which reacts first to weaker demand: the commodity, the producer, or market fear?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S19, S33

2019 Q2 / PULSE SOCIAL, HARBOR METAL, ATLAS CURRENCY PAIR
Central banks prepare support
CONFIRMED BRIEF

Policy makers are discussing lower rates as global growth slows, reducing financing pressure but also changing currency and metal incentives.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Markets may already expect more easing than officials will deliver.

ASK THE ROOM

Who benefits most when rates fall but expectations are already high?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Harbor Metal, Atlas Currency Pair. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S21, S22, S23, S32

2019 Q3 / HARBOR METAL
Rate cuts return to the conversation
CONFIRMED BRIEF

Trade uncertainty is rising and policy makers are becoming more willing to support growth.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Large long-term funds may be rebuilding defensive positions.

ASK THE ROOM

Would easier policy change the opportunity cost of holding metal?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare safe-haven demand with the opportunity cost created by yields and dollar strength.

SOURCE IDS

S21, S22, S23

**2019 Q3 / PULSE
SOCIAL, ASTER
THERAPEUTICS,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX****Lower rates revive risk appetite****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Easier financial conditions support advertising, healthcare valuations, and broader equity demand while the cost of protection falls.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

A temporary trade agreement may be closer than public statements suggest.

ASK THE ROOM

How can one macro change lift very different businesses at the same time?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Aster Therapeutics, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S21, S22, S28

**2019 Q3 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE****Supply discipline steadies energy****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Producers are limiting new spending and inventories are no longer rising as quickly, even though demand growth remains modest.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Independent producers may cut drilling plans again.

ASK THE ROOM

Is stabilization enough to help a highly indebted producer?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S19, S33

**2019 Q4 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY****Big deal, bigger balance sheet****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

An oil producer has committed to a major acquisition. Investors now have to judge the extra production against the extra debt.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Credit desks are questioning whether the dividend can stay untouched.

ASK THE ROOM

What could go right - and what must go right?

DEBRIEF LENS

Ask whether stronger commodity cash flow is enough to compensate for leverage and execution risk.

SOURCE IDS

S08

**2019 Q4 / PULSE
SOCIAL, CEDAR RIDGE
ENERGY, MERIDIAN
CRUDE, MARKET
NERVES INDEX****Health emergency threatens global activity****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Travel, manufacturing, and in-person commerce are suddenly at risk as a new illness spreads across borders and forecasts are cut rapidly.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Restrictions may last longer than early official estimates.

ASK THE ROOM

Which assets face direct demand destruction, and which mainly face a confidence shock?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S25, S28, S34

**2019 Q4 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS,
HARBOR METAL**

Investors search for resilience and cash

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Healthcare demand looks comparatively stable and defensive metal is wanted as insurance, although forced selling could briefly pressure almost everything.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Emergency policy support may arrive faster than in past crises.

ASK THE ROOM

Can a defensive asset fall temporarily during a rush for cash?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Aster Therapeutics, Harbor Metal. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S13, S23, S24

2020 NEWSROOM

Quarter cards: 2020

Release each card only when its game quarter is reached. Source IDs point to the appendix; the card wording is a fictionalized synthesis rather than a quotation.

**2020 Q1 / MERIDIAN
CRUDE**

Travel stops and storage fills

CONFIRMED BRIEF

A global health emergency is cutting transport demand much faster than producers can reduce supply.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Physical traders say available storage is disappearing faster than public data suggests.

ASK THE ROOM

What happens when a physical product has nowhere to go?

DEBRIEF LENS

Trace the physical chain: demand, production response, storage and regional transport limits.

SOURCE IDS

S25, S33

**2020 Q1 / MARKET
NERVES INDEX**

Stress gauge flashes red

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Option prices show investors paying unusually high amounts for protection as uncertainty spreads across markets.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Some desks are selling even their safest assets just to raise cash.

ASK THE ROOM

Does extreme fear warn of more danger, or signal forced selling?

DEBRIEF LENS

This broad-market gauge comes from SPX options. Single-stock chaos can coexist with a calm VIX.

SOURCE IDS

S28, S34

**2020 Q1 / PULSE
SOCIAL, ASTER
THERAPEUTICS,
HARBOR METAL,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX**

Emergency support changes expectations

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Governments and central banks launch large support programs while digital activity and essential healthcare demand remain strong.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Investors may move from maximum fear to recovery bets before the economy reopens.

ASK THE ROOM

Which assets can recover while the real economy is still weak?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Aster Therapeutics, Harbor Metal, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S04, S14, S24, S28, S34

**2020 Q1 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE**

Historic supply cuts follow the collapse

CONFIRMED BRIEF

After storage stress and a demand crash, producers announce deep output cuts and some transport activity begins to recover from extremely low levels.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Temporary well closures may become permanent supply reductions.

ASK THE ROOM

Can terrible current conditions create the setup for a sharp rebound?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S25, S33

2020 Q2 / HARBOR METAL**Emergency support changes the macro picture****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Central banks and governments are launching unusually large support programs after a rush for cash.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

New buyers are treating defensive metal as insurance against the policy response.

ASK THE ROOM

Could the same policy calm markets and create a new long-term risk?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare safe-haven demand with the opportunity cost created by yields and dollar strength.

SOURCE IDS

S24

2020 Q2 / PULSE SOCIAL**Digital demand recovers unevenly****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Online activity stays elevated and large advertisers return faster than small businesses, improving the outlook for a global ad platform.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Shopping activity inside social apps may be accelerating.

ASK THE ROOM

Does a shift in where people spend time create a durable advantage?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S04

2020 Q2 / CEDAR RIDGE ENERGY, MERIDIAN CRUDE, MARKET NERVES INDEX**Oil rebounds, balance sheets lag****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Crude prices recover from extreme lows, but indebted producers still face weak cash flow and refinancing pressure as market fear gradually declines.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Lenders may demand asset sales even if the commodity keeps improving.

ASK THE ROOM

Why might the commodity recover before the company that produces it?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S09, S25, S28, S33

2020 Q3 / PULSE SOCIAL**Online activity jumps, advertising stays uneven****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

People are spending more time on digital services, but many small advertisers remain under pressure.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Internal usage figures may be stronger than the company has shared publicly.

ASK THE ROOM

Which is more important for this business: attention or advertiser budgets?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S04

**2020 Q3 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX****Vaccine progress strengthens reopening bets****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Encouraging vaccine results improve expectations for travel and fuel demand, helping energy markets while reducing demand for protection.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Distribution could begin sooner than conservative forecasts assume.

ASK THE ROOM

Which prices move first when investors anticipate reopening months ahead?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S09, S14, S26, S28

**2020 Q3 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS****Research pipeline broadens beyond the crisis****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

A medicines company reports progress across both emergency treatments and longer-term metabolic and neurological programs.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

One non-pandemic program may eventually matter more than the emergency treatment.

ASK THE ROOM

How should investors compare temporary revenue with a durable pipeline?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S14, S15

**2020 Q4 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS****Treatment data draws attention****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

A healthcare company reports encouraging emergency-treatment evidence while its core business remains stable.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Another late-stage trial could become the larger story.

ASK THE ROOM

How should a one-off catalyst be compared with the core business?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S14, S15

**2020 Q4 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX****Reopening improves the cash-flow map****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Vaccinations begin, mobility forecasts rise, and producers hold back spending, creating a better supply-demand outlook and calmer markets.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Energy inventories may normalize faster than expected.

ASK THE ROOM

How does restrained supply amplify a demand recovery?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S09, S26, S33

**2020 Q4 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS****Metabolic treatment clears an important hurdle****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Late-stage data show meaningful improvements in a large chronic-disease market, strengthening confidence in a future product launch.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Doctors may use the treatment more broadly than the initial label suggests.

ASK THE ROOM

What makes a clinical result commercially important rather than merely interesting?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S16

2021 NEWSROOM

Quarter cards: 2021

Release each card only when its game quarter is reached. Source IDs point to the appendix; the card wording is a fictionalized synthesis rather than a quotation.

**2021 Q1 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY**

Reopening lifts fuel expectations

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Mobility is improving and producers are still cautious about adding supply. One producer is using stronger cash flow to repair its finances.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Value investors are quietly revisiting companies they avoided last year.

ASK THE ROOM

How quickly can better conditions repair a weak balance sheet?

DEBRIEF LENS

Ask whether stronger commodity cash flow is enough to compensate for leverage and execution risk.

SOURCE IDS

S10, S26

**2021 Q1 / PULSE
SOCIAL, CEDAR RIDGE
ENERGY, ASTER
THERAPEUTICS,
MERIDIAN CRUDE,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX**

Reopening lifts several kinds of demand

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Mobility, advertising, elective healthcare, and industrial activity improve together while market protection becomes less expensive.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Household savings may support a stronger spending burst than forecasts show.

ASK THE ROOM

Which businesses gain directly, and which gain mainly through confidence?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Cedar Ridge Energy, Aster Therapeutics, Meridian Crude, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S04, S09, S16, S26, S28

**2021 Q1 / HARBOR
METAL, ATLAS
CURRENCY PAIR**

Recovery changes the rate debate

CONFIRMED BRIEF

One economy is recovering faster, pushing its bond yields higher and changing the relative appeal of defensive metal and major currencies.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Policy makers may tolerate higher inflation for longer than bond traders expect.

ASK THE ROOM

How do relative rates connect a currency pair and a defensive metal?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Harbor Metal, Atlas Currency Pair. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S23, S29, S32

**2021 Q2 / MARKET
NERVES INDEX****Calmer index, noisy corners****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

The broad-market stress gauge is lower, even while a few individual companies are moving wildly.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Some traders warn that a calm headline index can hide risk concentrated in single stocks.

ASK THE ROOM

Can a market look calm while parts of it are unstable?

DEBRIEF LENS

This broad-market gauge comes from SPX options. Single-stock chaos can coexist with a calm VIX.

SOURCE IDS

S27, S28

**2021 Q2 / MARKET
NERVES INDEX,
MERIDIAN CRUDE****A new variant tests the calm****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

A more contagious virus variant creates uncertainty about travel even as vaccination keeps the base-case recovery intact.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Options traders may be underpricing short-term disruption.

ASK THE ROOM

When does a setback change the trend rather than merely interrupt it?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Market Nerves Index, Meridian Crude. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S26, S28

**2021 Q2 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS****Two programs strengthen the growth case****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Positive metabolic data and a regulatory breakthrough designation improve the odds that new medicines can expand future sales.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Manufacturing capacity may become the next constraint.

ASK THE ROOM

What new risk appears after scientific uncertainty falls?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S16, S17

**2021 Q3 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS****Two research programs approach key updates****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

A drugmaker has more than one late-stage program that could affect its future growth story.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Specialist discussions describe one dataset as unusually strong.

ASK THE ROOM

How much confidence belongs in a story before full data arrives?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S16, S17

**2021 Q3 / MARKET
NERVES INDEX, ATLAS
CURRENCY PAIR,
HARBOR METAL****Inflation changes policy expectations****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Persistent inflation leads traders to expect earlier tightening, supporting one side of a major currency pair and challenging defensive metal.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Bond markets may be moving faster than central-bank guidance.

ASK THE ROOM

How can fear rise even when economic growth remains healthy?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Market Nerves Index, Atlas Currency Pair, Harbor Metal. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S23, S28, S29, S32

**2021 Q3 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS****Strong data expand the addressable market****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Research results suggest a metabolic treatment could serve a much larger patient group than investors assumed a year ago.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Early demand forecasts may still underestimate physician interest.

ASK THE ROOM

How should a larger potential market change valuation before launch?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S16, S17

**2021 Q4 / PULSE
SOCIAL****A new identity comes with a large bill****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

A consumer internet company is redirecting investment toward a long-term platform idea while near-term growth becomes less certain.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

The rebrand may be distracting leaders from the existing advertising engine.

ASK THE ROOM

When is long-term investment a strength, and when is it a warning?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S05, S06

**2021 Q4 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY,
MERIDIAN CRUDE****Energy supply struggles to match reopening****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Demand has returned near pre-crisis levels while producer investment remains restrained, improving cash flow for efficient oil companies.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

A prominent long-term investor may be accumulating shares in the sector.

ASK THE ROOM

How does scarcity affect the commodity and a leveraged producer differently?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S10, S26, S33

**2021 Q4 / PULSE
SOCIAL, MARKET
NERVES INDEX****Higher rates expose expensive growth plans****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

User growth slows just as rates rise and a consumer platform commits heavily to a long-dated project with uncertain returns.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Advertising measurement problems may be worse than management first expected.

ASK THE ROOM

Why do higher rates magnify a company-specific execution problem?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S05, S06, S28

2022 NEWSROOM

Quarter cards: 2022

Release each card only when its game quarter is reached. Source IDs point to the appendix; the card wording is a fictionalized synthesis rather than a quotation.

**2022 Q1 / MERIDIAN
CRUDE**

Conflict threatens a major supply route

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Sanctions and transport uncertainty are forcing buyers to rethink where energy will come from.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Regional shortages may be more severe than the global benchmark suggests.

ASK THE ROOM

Is the shock temporary, or will trade routes change for longer?

DEBRIEF LENS

Trace the physical chain: demand, production response, storage and regional transport limits.

SOURCE IDS

S30

**2022 Q1 / CEDAR
RIDGE ENERGY**

Stronger prices transform the debt story

CONFIRMED BRIEF

An oil producer is generating far more cash as the energy market tightens, giving management new choices about debt and shareholder returns.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

A famous long-term investor may still be adding to a position.

ASK THE ROOM

How should improved cash flow change the way you view old debt?

DEBRIEF LENS

Ask whether stronger commodity cash flow is enough to compensate for leverage and execution risk.

SOURCE IDS

S11

**2022 Q1 / PULSE
SOCIAL**

Short-form competition pressures engagement

CONFIRMED BRIEF

A mature social platform faces stronger competition for younger users while privacy changes make advertising results harder to measure.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Management may increase spending before engagement stabilizes.

ASK THE ROOM

Can a profitable core business offset weakening user momentum?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S06

**2022 Q1 / ASTER
THERAPEUTICS**

Trial results point to a very large market

CONFIRMED BRIEF

A late-stage obesity study reports unusually strong results, increasing expectations for demand across metabolic disease treatment.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Insurers may cover the treatment sooner than expected.

ASK THE ROOM

What must happen after strong science for shareholders to benefit?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S18

2022 Q2 / HARBOR METAL**War risk meets aggressive rate hikes****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Demand for protection remains, while faster policy tightening and a stronger dollar raise the cost of holding defensive metal.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Some desks expect a round trip rather than a clean trend.

ASK THE ROOM

Which force is likely to last longer?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare safe-haven demand with the opportunity cost created by yields and dollar strength.

SOURCE IDS

S29, S31

2022 Q2 / CEDAR RIDGE ENERGY, MERIDIAN CRUDE**Recession fears challenge the energy spike****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Rapid rate increases and slowing activity forecasts reduce expected fuel demand after an extreme war-driven price surge.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Physical shortages may ease before geopolitical risk disappears.

ASK THE ROOM

Can demand fear overpower a genuine supply problem?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Cedar Ridge Energy, Meridian Crude. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S11, S30, S33

2022 Q2 / PULSE SOCIAL, HARBOR METAL, ATLAS CURRENCY PAIR, MARKET NERVES INDEX**A stronger dollar tightens global conditions****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Faster US rate increases strengthen the dollar, pressure a major currency pair and defensive metal, and keep volatility elevated.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Crowded dollar positions may eventually become vulnerable to reversal.

ASK THE ROOM

Which move is driven by fundamentals, and which may be driven by positioning?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Pulse Social, Harbor Metal, Atlas Currency Pair, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S29, S31, S32, S34

2022 Q3 / ASTER THERAPEUTICS**A new treatment could face a supply problem****CONFIRMED BRIEF**

Demand expectations for an obesity treatment are rising so quickly that manufacturing capacity is becoming part of the debate.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Early channel checks suggest demand could run ahead of production.

ASK THE ROOM

Can very strong demand still create an execution risk?

DEBRIEF LENS

Distinguish dependable core sales from uncertain trial, approval and capacity outcomes.

SOURCE IDS

S18

**2022 Q3 / HARBOR
METAL, ATLAS
CURRENCY PAIR,
MARKET NERVES
INDEX**

Inflation shows early signs of cooling

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Softer inflation data raise hopes that rate increases can slow, weakening the dollar from extreme levels and calming market stress.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Policy makers may still resist declaring victory.

ASK THE ROOM

Why can markets turn before central banks officially change direction?

DEBRIEF LENS

Compare how the shared signal could affect Harbor Metal, Atlas Currency Pair, Market Nerves Index. Ask students to separate direct effects from indirect effects and explain why the assets may react by different amounts.

SOURCE IDS

S29, S31, S32, S34

**2022 Q3 / PULSE
SOCIAL**

Weak advertising meets heavy spending

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Advertisers cut budgets as economic growth slows, while a consumer platform continues investing heavily in an uncertain long-term project.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Cost reductions may arrive later than investors want.

ASK THE ROOM

Which matters more during a slowdown: current revenue weakness or future investment discipline?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S07

**2022 Q4 / PULSE
SOCIAL**

Advertisers question measurement

CONFIRMED BRIEF

Privacy changes make digital ads harder to measure just as higher rates make distant profits less valuable.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Some buyers say the measurement problem is worse than public guidance implies.

ASK THE ROOM

Are these two separate risks, or can they reinforce each other?

DEBRIEF LENS

Separate user attention from advertiser economics, then add regulation and discount-rate risk.

SOURCE IDS

S06, S07

**2022 Q4 / ATLAS
CURRENCY PAIR**

Rate gaps pull currencies apart

CONFIRMED BRIEF

One central bank is tightening faster while energy costs put different pressure on the two economies in a major currency pair.

FICTIONAL RUMOR

Positioning may be crowded after a long move in the same direction.

ASK THE ROOM

Does a strong trend become safer or riskier when everyone sees it?

DEBRIEF LENS

A higher proxy means euro strength and dollar weakness; compare policy and growth on both sides.

SOURCE IDS

S29, S32

DEBRIEF TOOLKIT

Make the reasoning visible

Use these prompts after results are marked. Ask for evidence before showing the real mapping.

**FACT, RUMOR OR
INFERENCE?**

Choose one statement your team used. Was it confirmed information, unverified chatter or your own conclusion?

**WHAT CHANGED
YOUR MIND?**

Name the single clue or price move that caused the largest update to your view.

**WAS
CONFIDENCE
CALIBRATED?**

Compare your stated confidence with the strength and independence of your evidence.

**OUTCOME
VERSUS PROCESS**

Would you make the same decision again with the same information, even if the result was poor?

**WHAT STAYED
HIDDEN?**

List information a real analyst would still want before making a larger decision.

Plain-language glossary

Catalyst An event that could change expectations or price.	Hedge A position intended to reduce another risk.
Leverage Debt or borrowing that can magnify gains and losses.	Liquidity How easily an asset can be traded without a large price change.
Rate differential The gap between interest rates in two economies.	Real yield An interest rate after accounting for expected inflation.
Short covering Buying that closes an earlier bet on a falling price.	Volatility How widely and quickly prices move.

SOURCE APPENDIX

Authoritative anchors

These sources calibrate historical themes and the simplified proxy traces. They do not turn a fictional card into a dated transcript. Access checks were completed on 10 July 2026.

Stock A

S01	Statement on reported concerns about Facebook privacy practices Federal Trade Commission / 2018-03-26 https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2018/03/statement-acting-director-ftcs-bureau-consumer-protection-regarding-reported-concerns-about-facebook
S02	Facebook reports second quarter 2018 results Facebook / 2018-07-25 https://investor.fb.com/files/doc_financials/2018/Q2/Facebook-Reports-Second-Quarter-2018-Results.pdf
S03	Facebook reports fourth quarter and full year 2019 results Meta Investor Relations / 2020-01-29 https://investor.atmeta.com/investor-news/press-release-details/2020/Facebook-Reports-Fourth-Quarter-and-Full-Year-2019-Results/default.aspx
S04	Facebook reports fourth quarter and full year 2020 results Meta Investor Relations / 2021-01-27 https://investor.atmeta.com/investor-news/press-release-details/2021/Facebook-Reports-Fourth-Quarter-and-Full-Year-2020-Results/default.aspx
S05	Introducing Meta: a social technology company Meta / 2021-10-28 https://about.fb.com/news/2021/10/facebook-company-is-now-meta/
S06	Meta reports fourth quarter and full year 2021 results Meta Investor Relations / 2022-02-02 https://investor.atmeta.com/investor-news/press-release-details/2022/Meta-Reports-Fourth-Quarter-and-Full-Year-2021-Results/default.aspx
S07	Meta reports fourth quarter and full year 2022 results Meta Investor Relations / 2023-02-01 https://investor.atmeta.com/investor-news/press-release-details/2023/Meta-Reports-Fourth-Quarter-and-Full-Year-2022-Results/default.aspx

Stock B

S08	Occidental completes acquisition of Anadarko U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission archive / 2019-08-08 https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/797468/000095015719000864/ex99-1.htm
S09	Occidental announces fourth quarter and full year 2020 results Occidental Petroleum / 2021-02-22 https://www.oxy.com/siteassets/documents/investors/quarterly-earnings/OXY4Q20EarningsRelease.pdf
S10	Occidental announces fourth quarter 2021 results Occidental Petroleum / 2022-02-24 https://www.oxy.com/siteassets/documents/investors/quarterly-earnings/oxy4q21earningspressrelease_financials2.pdf
S11	Occidental announces fourth quarter 2022 results Occidental Petroleum / 2023-02-27 https://www.oxy.com/news/news-releases/occidental-announces-4th-quarter-2022-results/

Stock C

S12	Lilly reports fourth quarter and full year 2018 financial results Eli Lilly / 2019-02-06 https://investor.lilly.com/news-releases/news-release-details/lilly-reports-strong-fourth-quarter-and-full-year-2018-financial
S13	Lilly to acquire Loxo Oncology Eli Lilly / 2019-01-07 https://investor.lilly.com/node/40136
S14	FDA authorizes monoclonal antibody treatment for COVID-19 U.S. Food and Drug Administration / 2020-11-09 https://www.fda.gov/news-events/press-announcements/coronavirus-covid-19-update-fda-authorizes-monoclonal-antibody-treatment-covid-19
S15	FDA revokes authorization for bamlanivimab when administered alone U.S. Food and Drug Administration / 2021-04-16 https://www.fda.gov/news-events/press-announcements/coronavirus-covid-19-update-fda-revokes-emergency-use-authorization-monoclonal-antibody-bamlanivimab
S16	Tirzepatide achieves primary and key secondary study endpoints Eli Lilly / 2021-05-20 https://investor.lilly.com/news-releases/news-release-details/lillys-tirzepatide-achieves-all-primary-and-key-secondary-study
S17	Donanemab receives FDA Breakthrough Therapy designation Eli Lilly / 2021-06-24 https://investor.lilly.com/news-releases/news-release-details/lillys-donanemab-receives-us-fdas-breakthrough-therapy
S18	SURMOUNT-1 tirzepatide obesity trial results Eli Lilly / 2022-04-28 https://investor.lilly.com/news-releases/news-release-details/lillys-tirzepatide-delivered-225-weight-loss-adults-obesity-or

Macro and energy

S19	Crude oil prices declined in fourth quarter 2018 U.S. Energy Information Administration / 2019-01-03 https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=37852
S20	Federal Reserve issues FOMC statement Federal Reserve / 2019-03-20 https://www.federalreserve.gov/newsevents/pressreleases/monetary20190320a.htm
S21	Federal Reserve issues FOMC statement Federal Reserve / 2019-07-31 https://www.federalreserve.gov/newsevents/pressreleases/monetary20190731a.htm
S22	ECB monetary policy decisions European Central Bank / 2019-09-12 https://www.ecb.europa.eu/press/pr/date/2019/html/ecb.mp190912~08de50b4d2.en.html
S23	Gold demand trends: full year 2019 World Gold Council / 2020-01-30 https://www.gold.org/goldhub/research/gold-demand-trends/gold-demand-trends-full-year-2019
S24	Gold prices swing as markets sell off World Gold Council / 2020-03-19 https://www.gold.org/goldhub/research/gold-prices-swing-as-markets-sell-off
S25	Low liquidity and limited storage pushed WTI futures below zero U.S. Energy Information Administration / 2020-04-27 https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=43495
S26	Global liquid fuels consumption returned toward 2019 levels U.S. Energy Information Administration / 2021-11-09 https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=50296

S27	Staff report on equity and options market structure conditions in early 2021 U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission / 2021-10-18 https://www.sec.gov/about/reports-publications/staff-report-equity-options-market-structure-conditions-early-2021
S28	Cboe VIX FAQ: definition, calculation and products Cboe / 2018-05-15 https://www.cboe.com/tradable_products/vix/faqs
S29	FOMC projections materials Federal Reserve / 2021-12-15 https://www.federalreserve.gov/monetarypolicy/fomcproptabl20211215.htm
S30	Crude oil prices were lower in 2022 than in 2021 by year end U.S. Energy Information Administration / 2023-01-04 https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=55079
S31	Gold market commentary: December 2022 World Gold Council / 2023-01-09 https://www.gold.org/goldhub/research/gold-market-commentary-december-2022

Calibration data

S32	FRED U.S. dollars to euro exchange rate series DEXUSEU Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis / accessed 2026-07-10 https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/DEXUSEU
S33	Cushing WTI spot price history U.S. Energy Information Administration / accessed 2026-07-10 https://www.eia.gov/dnav/pet/hist/rwtcd.htm
S34	VIX historical data Cboe / accessed 2026-07-10 https://www.cboe.com/tradable_products/vix/vix_historical_data